INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #55 · FORGIVING OTHERS

“I'm a poor Christian because I can't forgive.”

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Where it often comes from

When we hear that Christians must forgive, and we cannot, guilt can pile on top of the original hurt. Some of us have tried and failed, been told to “just let it go,” or hear sermons that make forgiveness sound easy. We conclude that our faith is defective.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture says, “He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust.” “A bruised reed He will not break and a smoldering wick He will not extinguish.” Paul writes, “Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead, I press on,” describing growth as a process, not an instant arrival. Peter himself asked how many times to forgive, which shows that forgiveness is hard even for disciples. David prayed, “Create in me a clean heart, O God.” Struggling to forgive means you are in the middle of a hard thing, not that you have failed at faith. “There is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.”

> *“Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me”* (Psalm 51:10).

Also see

> “A bruised reed He will not break and a smoldering wick He will not extinguish; He will faithfully bring forth justice” (Isaiah 42:3).

> “Brothers, I do not consider myself yet to have taken hold of it. But one thing I do: Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead” (Philippians 3:13).

> “Then Peter came to Jesus and asked, ‘Lord, how many times shall I forgive my brother who sins against me? Up to seven times?’ Jesus answered, ‘I tell you, not just seven times, but seventy-seven times!’” (Matthew 18:21–22).

> “Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” (Romans 8:1).

Common self-statements

- A real Christian would have forgiven by now.
- Something is wrong with my faith.
- God is disappointed in me.
- Others forgive more easily.
- I am failing God.
- I should be over this.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I should have forgiven already.
- Labeling: Calling myself a poor Christian.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I either forgave fully or failed.
- Social comparison: Comparing my process with others’ apparent ease.

Challenging questions

- What makes this hurt so hard to release?

- Is difficulty the same as failure?
- What steps have I already taken toward forgiveness?
- How does God treat me when I struggle?
- Who can walk with me through this?
- What honest prayer could I pray today?

Truth summary

> Struggling to forgive does not make me a poor Christian. God knows I am dust and does not break a bruised reed. Forgiveness is often a process, and I can keep taking honest steps with His help.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgiveness
- Forgive
- Guilt/Shame
- Mercy
- Weakness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anger
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Worn — Tenth Avenue North
Weariness can be expressed honestly while asking God for restoration.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "I'm a poor Christian because I can't forgive"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'm a poor Christian because I can't forgive." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What makes this hard?
- ☐ What steps have I taken?
- ☐ How does God treat me?
- ☐ Who can help?
- ☐ What can I pray honestly?
- ☐ What is my next step?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God knows I am dust.
- ☐ He does not break a bruised reed.
- ☐ Forgiveness can be a process.
- ☐ There is no condemnation for me.
- ☐ I can keep taking steps.
- ☐ He can create a clean heart in me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 51:10
  "Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me."
- ☐ Isaiah 42:3
  "A bruised reed He will not break and a smoldering wick He will not extinguish; He will faithfully bring forth justice."
- ☐ Romans 8:1
  "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Steps toward: Each week, record one step toward forgiveness, however small.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 51:10 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Create in me a clean heart, O God.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Forgiveness" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the difficulty. Write what makes forgiveness hard.
- [ ] Pray honestly. Tell God you are struggling and ask for help.
- [ ] Take one small step. Pray for the person once, or write a letter you do not send.
- [ ] Get support. Talk with a counselor or pastor about the process.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'm a poor Christian because I can't forgive": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A step toward
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'm a poor Christian because I can't forgive.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, forgiving is hard for me. Thank You that You do not break the bruised reed. Create in me a clean heart, and help me take the next step, however small. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.